

Why don't our husbands go to Rhodesia?
Because they have killed a European there.

The women are trying to shame their men into going south by suggesting that they are afraid of white men. Some songs speak of the results when men become "machona"--lost ones who never return home. These, the Visekese song, is sung occasionally on moonlit nights during the season when women are longing for their men.

Imwe mukuya ku joni mukawa pharile
ngeko, ine nkule, anyina wo nkule.

If you meet him in South Africa, tell him
that I am naked and his mother is naked.

They sung while doing the Cimtale dance which is performed at celebrations and political gatherings is a good example of the sardonic wit characteristic of Malawian women.

Amuna naji ochoka pososa.
Adzadya telyine.

The men are leaving without preparing the fields.
They will eat teryline.

and shirts made from teryline fabric are popular among men who have worked in Rhodesia and South Africa. If they leave home before helping their wives prepare their gardens, they will have to eat their shirts when they return since the granaries are empty (interviews 1972). These songs indicate a practical approach to emigration from the female point of view. Working in the south is encouraged because it is a source of wealth; arrangements should be made for the family's safekeeping and departure; and the men should not stay away for extended periods. Actually, it is the policy fostered by colonial and independent administrations in Malawi since 1966.

Throughout the twentieth century governmental authorities have sought ways to control "free flow" independent emigration which has been much more popular than official arrangements. Malawians always preferred to choose their own employer rather than offer themselves to the mercies of recruiting agents. However, controls were needed because too many taxpayers were being lost, some but not all of the men needed to make adequate provisions for their families in their absence, and others disappeared without a trace. In addition, tea planters invariably complained of labor shortages during plucking season and pressed for the complete prohibition of emigration. This approach to the problem was unrealistic since men continued to go abroad regardless of legal restraints.

Except for the years between 1903 and 1909 when the Witwatersrand Native Labor Association (Wenela) recruited in the Protectorate, there was no authorized recruiting for employment outside the country until 1935, when the London and Nyasaland Supply Company (now Kandodo) became the local recruiting agents for South African gold mines (Burden 1940). In 1938, after Wenela had taken over again, contracts were offered for two years, recruits were given medical examinations, wage rates enabled the men to pay their taxes before leaving home, free transportation was provided, deferred pay and family remittance was